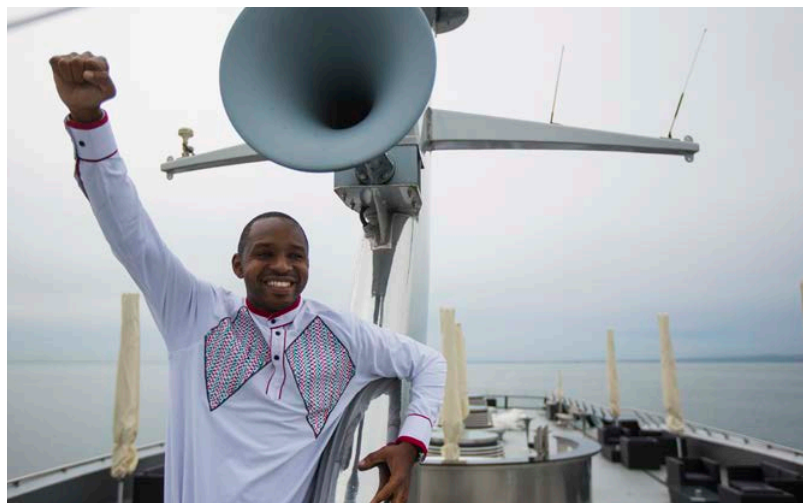


THE BATTLE OF A LIFETIME

GET INVOLVED – Kenyan social activist Boniface Mwangi is restless when it comes to his fight for real democracy and putting power in the hands of young people.

NATASHA R. SILVA (TEXT),
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Boniface Mwangi's path towards social activism was bumpy. After working as a photojournalist for four years and winning several awards, he suddenly decided to give it all up.

It was December 2008, and the timing was far from perfect: Mwangi was recently married and did not have any savings in the bank. However, the change was imperative. Just a year before, between December 2007 and February 2008, a wave of violence spread across Kenya after a disputed presidential election. Mwangi reported on the clashes for *The Standard* newspaper.

The conflict was finally solved, leaving more than 1,000 people dead and about 600,000 displaced. Mwangi went back to his regular work, but was haunted by the pictures he had taken. "I could not stand politicians at that particular time, and my job was to go and take pictures of them," he recalls. Feeling like he could not take it anymore, he turned to social activism to transform his country.

"As a journalist you inform. But as an activist you can do more than talk, you can try and change the problem you talk about. That is what I am trying to do," Mwangi says.

Since 2011, he has led Pawa 254, a creative hub in Nairobi that connects young people from different backgrounds to promote social change through art. "It is not only about using your art to make money. Money is good to make, but it is also about speaking out against poverty and inequality," Mwangi says.

However, it is not that simple to make those changes happen. Mwangi admits that, like many young people, when he started to be an activist he was very anxious to see the results of his work. Now he knows that meaningful changes take a while to happen. "Those are battles of a lifetime. I was a little naïve then. I thought everything was going to happen like this [snaps his fingers]. But it doesn't happen that fast. Change is a very slow, painful process. I learned how to be patient the hard way," he says with a smile.

Mwangi still has a lot of patience left. The former photojournalist turned social activist feels like his battle to change Kenya is far from over. The same goes for his career changes. First photojournalist, then activist, next – politician? "I think there is a need to find ways to work from within the system," he says. "So maybe in a few years I will be working as a lawmaker. It's something I am still thinking about."

For Mwangi, everything is part of a personal struggle. Having grown up in a poor family, he says that he has seen and felt the consequences of bad government up close. Now that he has fought for himself, Mwangi feels it is time to make a better life for his three children. "I feel that if I don't fight my battles right now, my kids will be forced to fight. So I have to pay the price for them," he says. That's why he's urging the youth of Kenya to join him: "We should stop leaving politics to the old men. And it is especially the old men," he says. Those men are not worried about the future. So let's not leave politics to them, let's get involved!